Test, at Kolkata, we cut off Sehwag at 81 and Tendulkar at 52. My modus operandi for batting was to open hard and hit their new-ball bowlers for the gallows. I had a strike rate of 119 in that game, with 29 from 21 in the first innings and 59 from 59 in the second. Too bad we lost by 195 runs.

In the Bangalore Test, which we won, thus levelling the series, I got three important wickets – Tendulkar, Ganguly and V.V.S. Laxman – in the second innings. I went through Ganguly's gate with a lot of movement, almost a metre in through a drive that he directed towards Bihar, not Bengal. He didn't leave the crease for a couple of minutes, thinking he'd been stumped, not bowled. It was fun watching him flummoxed. For Sachin, I kept it straight – we wore him out over a hundred balls before he reached double digits (to his credit, in that series he would beat Sunil Gavaskar's record for most Test runs, though). On the fourth afternoon, I hit 58 off 34, and almost beat Jacques Kallis's record of a Test 50 in 24 balls, just trailing by two balls. We went on to declare our innings with a lead of almost 400. Having been written off by even the Pakistan media, winning the game after trailing the series 1–0 was special. We won by 168 runs and the crowd, too, appreciated our performance. But here was a series that forced an Indian rethink too: Dravid's rise, Ganguly's fall – he was jeered by the Bangalore crowd – and cheers for Inzi, particularly at the presentation ceremony.

In the ODIs, it was classic India versus Pakistan. My strike rate was 173 across six matches. I got a century in Kanpur and took the pressure off our bowlers. We won the ODI series comprehensively (4–2) and President Musharraf even attended the last match in Delhi. Ganguly was hung up to dry by the press. Sehwag emerged as the mainstay pace-killer for India. Tendulkar kept obsessing over breaking Gavaskar's record of 35 centuries. We missed Shoaib Akhtar in that series; he was out with a hamstring problem.

We had high expectations from that tour. This applied to everyone but it particularly mattered in the case of my coach and mentor. The magic ingredient for me and my personal success was Bob Woolmer. His was the Midas touch. He gave me a lot of confidence, right from the time of our first meeting in South Africa to when I was dropped for a year. He told me that it was in India where a Pakistani player has to stand up to his ultimate test of greatness. And, most importantly, Bob was the first coach who told me to be myself.